

Comparing the Decaying Turbulence Theory with Wind Tunnel Experiments

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Abstract

The Euler-ensemble solution of freely decaying incompressible turbulence predicts a universal, parameter-free second-order structure function $\langle(\Delta\mathbf{v})^2\rangle(r,t)$ as a Mellin–Barnes integral in the scaling variable $\rho = r/\sqrt{\tilde{\nu}(t+t_0)}$. We evaluate this integral for the odd Euler ensemble, the only marginally stable turbulent attractor, by steepest descent along Lefschetz thimbles with Gauss–Hermite quadrature, including the Stokes phenomenon: the residues of the Riemann-wall and dyadic-wall poles trapped by the thimble, and the thimbles that terminate on the paired zeros. The computation agrees with a direct contour integration to 5×10^{-10} . In contrast with the energy spectrum, where the same poles produce visible log-periodic oscillations, the effective index $\alpha(\rho) = \rho \partial_\rho \log \langle(\Delta\mathbf{v})^2\rangle$ is smooth: for $\rho > C_{\max}$ the structure function is a convergent series in real powers of $1/\rho$, and at small ρ the log-periodic part of α never exceeds 1.5×10^{-6} . Finite-size effects of a system of width W are included exactly by subtracting the infrared part $k < \pi/W$ of the spectrum, whose small- k expansion converges for all k . We compare the theory with the Max Planck wind-tunnel measurements of Küchler, Bewley and Bodenschatz at $Re_\lambda = 413\text{--}5779$. The small oscillations of the measured index at the largest separations are reproduced by the finite-width correction and disappear in the extrapolation to $Re_\lambda \rightarrow \infty$. The extrapolated tail of the index matches the odd-ensemble theory with a single scale parameter, $\chi^2/\text{dof} = 2.4$, weighted rms deviation 0.017. The theory also reproduces the whole index curve of recent 4096^3 direct numerical simulations.

I. INTRODUCTION

“Turbulence is an essentially statistical problem of the same type as one meets in statistical mechanics, since it is the problem of distribution of energy among a very large number of degrees of freedom.”

— W. Heisenberg [1]

The loop-space approach [2–4] reformulates the statistical evolution of freely decaying incompressible turbulence in terms of the circulation loop functional

$$\Psi(C, t) = \left\langle \exp \left(\frac{i}{\nu} \oint_C v_\alpha(x, t) dx_\alpha \right) \right\rangle, \quad (1)$$

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the fluid analogue of a Wilson loop, see the reviews [5, 6]. In the frame moving with the fluid, the Navier–Stokes statistical evolution becomes a linear diffusion equation in loop space. A functional Fourier transform maps it to the dual momentum loop $P_\alpha(\theta, t)$, a one-dimensional field on the ordering circle. The universal decaying solution of the momentum-loop equation has the form

$$P_\mu(\theta, t) = \frac{f_\mu(\theta)}{\sqrt{2\nu(t+t_0)}}, \quad \bar{f}(\Delta f^2 - 1) = (\Delta f \cdot \bar{f}) \Delta f, \quad (2)$$

with $\bar{f}$ and Δf the mean and the jump of f at the discretization points $\theta_k = 2\pi k/N$. The nontrivial solutions, with finite vorticity, require

$$f(\theta_k^+)^2 = f(\theta_k^-)^2, \quad (f(\theta_k^+) - f(\theta_k^-))^2 = 1 : \quad (3)$$

f lies on a sphere, and consecutive points are separated by unit steps. The dynamically selected planar sector is the *Euler ensemble* [3, 4, 6], a random walk on regular star polygons,

$$\mathbf{f}_k = \hat{\Omega} \cdot \{R \cos \alpha_k, R \sin \alpha_k, \vec{0}_\perp\}, \quad R = \frac{1}{2 \sin(\beta/2)}, \quad \alpha_k = \beta \sum_{l=1}^k \sigma_l, \quad \sigma_l = \pm 1, \quad (4)$$

with $\hat{\Omega} \in SO(d)$ a global rotation. Periodicity on the ordering circle makes the turning angle rational,

$$\beta = 2\pi \frac{p}{q}, \quad (p, q) = 1, \quad \sum_{l=1}^N \sigma_l = q r, \quad r \in \mathbb{Z}, \quad (5)$$

so the turbulent state is a uniform distribution over the regular star polygons $\{q/p\}$ (Fig. 1) and over the walks on them. The continuum limit $N \rightarrow \infty$ is taken at fixed turbulent viscosity $\tilde{\nu} = \nu N^2$, which keeps the energy dissipation rate finite [3, 5]. The Euler ensemble solves the discretized loop equation exactly, as confirmed by the rigorous analysis of Brué and De Lellis [7]. The nonlinear advection term cancels identically on the compact spherical target [6].

Two ensembles. The continuum limit depends on the parity of N . In the odd- N ensemble both q and r must be odd, whereas in the even- N ensemble at least one of them is even. The two limits are distinct superselection sectors, $\eta = N \bmod 2$, with a different prime-2 Euler factor in the corresponding Mellin sums [6]. Only the odd ensemble is marginally Lyapunov-stable in the statistical limit: it has infinitely many decaying modes and infinitely many zero modes. The even ensemble is unstable [8]. The odd ensemble is therefore the only marginally stable turbulent attractor, and it is the one compared with experiment below.

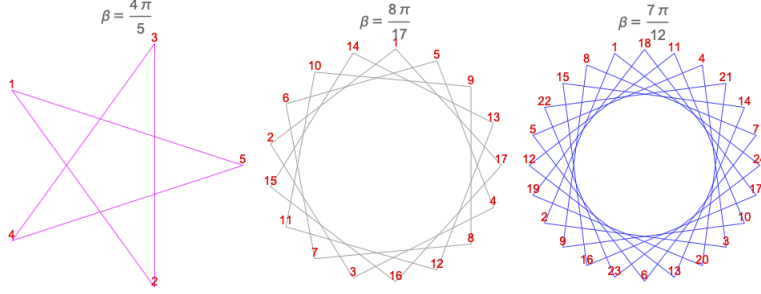


FIG. 1. Examples of the regular star polygons $\{q/p\}$ that form the discrete target space of the momentum loop. The turbulent state, the Euler ensemble, is a statistical average over random walks on all such polygons (from Ref. [5]).

Universal energy spectrum. The Euler ensemble gives the decaying energy spectrum in the self-similar form [4, 6]

$$E(k, t) = \frac{1}{L(t)} H(kL(t)), \quad L(t) = \sqrt{\tilde{\nu}(t + t_0)}, \quad H(\kappa) = \int_{\epsilon - i\infty}^{\epsilon + i\infty} \frac{dp}{2\pi i} M_\eta(p) \kappa^p, \quad (6)$$

with the parity-dependent Mellin amplitude

$$M_\eta(p) = \frac{f(p) \Gamma(-p) \zeta(p + \frac{15}{2})}{(2p + 7)(2p + 17) \zeta(p + \frac{17}{2}) (1 - \eta 2^{-(p+17/2)})}, \quad \eta = N \bmod 2, \quad (7)$$

where $f(p)$ is an entire function generated by the continuum limit of the Euler-ensemble path integral. It is independent of the space dimension $d > 1$ [5]. The strip of the Mellin integral is $-7/2 < \epsilon < 0$. Besides the real poles, M_η has the Riemann wall $P_n = -8 \pm i\gamma_n$, $\zeta(\frac{1}{2} + i\gamma_n) = 0$, paired with the zeros $Z_n = -7 \pm i\gamma_n$. In the odd ensemble it also has the dyadic wall $D_m = -\frac{17}{2} + 2\pi im / \log 2$, $m \neq 0$. When the Mellin integral (6) is evaluated by Lefschetz thimbles, these walls generate the Stokes staircase of the energy spectrum: as $\log \kappa$ grows, the thimble traps the wall poles one by one, each adding an exponentially small log-periodic correction $\kappa^{-8} \cos(\gamma_n \log \kappa + \phi_n)$ or $\kappa^{-17/2} \cos(2\pi m \log \kappa / \log 2 + \phi_m)$ [6].

This paper. Experiments do not measure $E(k, t)$ at fixed t over many decades; they measure the second-order structure function $\langle (\Delta \mathbf{v})^2 \rangle(r)$ and its local slope. Here we compute the effective index of the Euler-ensemble structure function by the same thimble method used for the spectrum [6]. We work out its Stokes structure and add the finite-size correction of a tunnel of finite width. We then compare the result with the Max Planck wind-tunnel data [9] extrapolated to infinite Reynolds number.

II. THE METHOD

A. Mellin–Barnes representation of the structure function

Multiplying (6) by the three-dimensional kernel $\sin(kr)/(kr)$ and integrating over k gives, with the scaling variable $\rho = r/L(t)$ and $p = -1 - q$,

$$G(\rho) \equiv \int_0^\infty d\kappa H(\kappa) \frac{\sin \kappa \rho}{\kappa \rho} = \int_{c-i\infty}^{c+i\infty} \frac{dq}{2\pi i} \rho^q Z_\eta(q), \quad -1 < c < 0, \quad (8)$$

$$\begin{aligned} Z_\eta(q) &= -\Gamma(-1-q) \cos \frac{\pi q}{2} M_\eta(-1-q) \\ &= -\frac{\pi}{2} \frac{\csc(\pi q/2) f(-1-q) \zeta\left(\frac{13}{2}-q\right)}{(1+q)(2q-15)(2q-5) \zeta\left(\frac{15}{2}-q\right) (1-\eta 2^{q-15/2})}, \end{aligned} \quad (9)$$

where $G(\rho)$ is the scaling function of the velocity correlation $\langle \mathbf{v}(0) \cdot \mathbf{v}(\mathbf{r}) \rangle$. The structure function $D(\rho) = 2(G(0) - G(\rho))$ is the same integral with the contour shifted across the pole at $q = 0$:

$$D(\rho) = \int_{c'-i\infty}^{c'+i\infty} \frac{dq}{2\pi i} \rho^q (-2Z_\eta(q)), \quad 0 < c' < 2, \quad \alpha(\rho) = \rho \partial_\rho \log D(\rho). \quad (10)$$

The Gamma function $\Gamma(-p)$ of the spectrum is cancelled by the Fourier kernel $\Gamma(p) \sin(\pi p/2)$, leaving $\csc(\pi q/2)$. Up to normalization, (9) is the kernel $V(p)$ of Refs. [4, 5] for $d = 3$, with the odd-ensemble factor. Its poles in q are:

- the real poles $q = -1, q = 2n$ ($n \in \mathbb{Z}$), $5/2, 11/2, 15/2$ (a double pole in the odd ensemble) and $15/2 + 2n$ ($n \geq 1$);
- the Riemann wall $7 \pm i\gamma_n$, with zeros at $6 \pm i\gamma_n$;
- the dyadic wall $15/2 \pm 2\pi i m / \log 2$.

All complex singularities lie to the *right*, at small ρ .

The entire function $f(p)$ is an integral over the polygon parameter Δ , $f(p) = 20 \int_{\Delta_1}^{\Delta_2} d\Delta (1 - \Delta) C^{p-1} (AC - Bp)$, with $A(\Delta), B(\Delta), C(\Delta)$ given in Ref. [4]. We evaluate it on a fixed Gauss–Legendre grid in Δ , which makes $f(p)$, $f'(p)$ and $f''(p)$ exact and cheap for every complex p . Since $C(\Delta) \in [C_{\min}, C_{\max}] = [e^{-2.915}, e^{-2.763}]$, the factor $f(-1-q) \sim C^{-2-q}$ fixes the convergence of the residue expansions:

- For $\rho > C_{\max}$ the contour closes to the left. $D(\rho)$ is then the convergent series $D = 2G(0) - 2(a_1 \rho^{-1} + \sum_{n \geq 1} b_n \rho^{-2n})$ in *real* powers, and $\alpha(\rho)$ has no oscillatory component at all.

- For $\rho < C_{\min}$ it closes to the right. $D = \sum_j c_j \rho^{q_j}$ over the right poles, and the only log-periodic terms are $\rho^{7 \pm i\gamma_n}$ and $\rho^{15/2 \pm 2\pi i m / \log 2}$.

In the crossover $C_{\min} \lesssim \rho \lesssim C_{\max}$ neither series converges, and the integral must be computed directly.

B. Lefschetz thimbles and Gauss–Hermite quadrature

Write $-2Z_\eta(q)\rho^q = e^{W(q)}$, $W(q) = S(q) + q \log \rho$. For every ρ there is one real saddle $q_0 \in (0, 2)$, $W'(q_0) = 0$, since $S'' > 0$ on the strip. As in Ref. [6], the thimble through q_0 is parametrized so that the weight decays as e^{-t^2} :

$$W(q(t)) = W(q_0) - t^2, \quad \frac{dq}{dt} = -\frac{2t}{W'(q)}, \quad q(\epsilon) = q_0 + \epsilon v_0, \quad v_0 = i\sqrt{\frac{2}{W''(q_0)}}, \quad (11)$$

with the lower branch $q(-t) = \overline{q(t)}$. The Gauss–Hermite rule with nodes and weights $\{t_j, w_j\}$ then gives

$$D_{\text{thimble}}(\rho) = \frac{e^{W(q_0)}}{\pi} \sum_{t_j > 0} w_j \operatorname{Im} g(t_j), \quad g(t) = e^{W(q(t)) - W(q_0) + t^2} q'(t). \quad (12)$$

On an exact thimble the exponential factor in g equals one. Keeping it makes (12) exact by Cauchy’s theorem even where the numerical path drifts from the thimble, and doubles as a drift diagnostic. The effective index uses the same nodes, $\rho \partial_\rho D_{\text{thimble}} = \pi^{-1} e^{W(q_0)} \sum_{t_j > 0} w_j \operatorname{Im} [q(t_j)g(t_j)]$, so no numerical differentiation is needed. The ODE (11) is integrated with the exact $S'(q)$, including f'/f .

C. Stokes phenomenon: trapped poles and zero parking

Because the complex walls of (9) lie to the right, the Stokes phenomenon of the structure function is the mirror image of that of the spectrum. A pole q_n is trapped between the vertical contour and the upper thimble when the rightward ray $\{\operatorname{Im} q = \operatorname{Im} q_n, \operatorname{Re} q > \operatorname{Re} q_n\}$ crosses the thimble an odd number of times. The orientation gives a minus sign:

$$D(\rho) = D_{\text{thimble}}(\rho) - 2 \operatorname{Re} \sum_{n \in \text{trapped}} \operatorname{Res}_{q=q_n} [-2Z_\eta(q)\rho^q], \quad (13)$$

with the Riemann-wall and dyadic-wall residues

$$\text{Res}_{q=7+i\gamma_n} = \frac{\pi \rho^q \csc(\pi q/2) f(-1-q) \zeta\left(\frac{13}{2}-q\right)}{(1+q)(2q-15)(2q-5) (1-2^{q-15/2}) \left(-\zeta'\left(\frac{15}{2}-q\right)\right)}, \quad (14)$$

$$\text{Res}_{q=15/2+2\pi i m/\log 2} = \frac{\pi \rho^q \csc(\pi q/2) f(-1-q) \zeta\left(\frac{13}{2}-q\right)}{(1+q)(2q-15)(2q-5) \zeta\left(\frac{15}{2}-q\right) (-\log 2)}, \quad (15)$$

checked against contour integrals around the poles to 10^{-12} . The thimbles fall into three regimes (Fig. 2):

1. For $\log \rho > -2.8$ the thimble bends to the left, where only real poles exist, and nothing is trapped. Near $\log \rho \approx -2.87$ it rises almost vertically and reaches the walls only at heights $\text{Im } q > 80$, where the residues are negligible.
2. For $-3.8 \leq \log \rho \leq -2.95$ the thimble *parks* on a zero $6 + i\gamma_n$ of Z_η , before reaching the Riemann wall. The contour then continues up $\text{Re } q = 6$, contributing a tail smaller than 10^{-14} in relative terms. The index n of the parking zero jumps $1, 2, 3, 5, 6, 7, 8, 14, \dots$ as $\log \rho \rightarrow -2.87$: this is the zero-parking staircase of the structure function (Fig. 3).
3. For $\log \rho < -3.85$ the thimble escapes to the right below the first zero and traps the whole Riemann and dyadic walls above its crossing height. The first dyadic pole, at height $2\pi/\log 2 = 9.06$, is trapped for $\log \rho < -4.2$.

D. Results for the infinite system

With 80 Gauss–Hermite nodes, the thimble plus Stokes terms (13) reproduce the direct integration of (10) along $\text{Re } q = 1$ over $-8 \leq \log \rho \leq 8$. The relative deviation is at most 5×10^{-10} for D , and the absolute deviation at most 4×10^{-10} for α (Fig. 4). The effective index falls monotonically from the dissipative value $\alpha \rightarrow 2$ at $\rho \rightarrow 0$ to $\alpha \rightarrow 0$ at $\rho \rightarrow \infty$, where $\alpha = a_1/(G(0)\rho) + O(\rho^{-2})$. There is no inertial plateau: the whole crossover takes place within $-5 \lesssim \log \rho \lesssim 0$.

Smooth structure function versus oscillating spectrum. The log-periodic part of α is the sum of all wall residues. It is shown in Fig. 5, together with the log-periodic part of the spectral index $d \log H / d \log \kappa$ computed from the same walls of (7). The dyadic wall

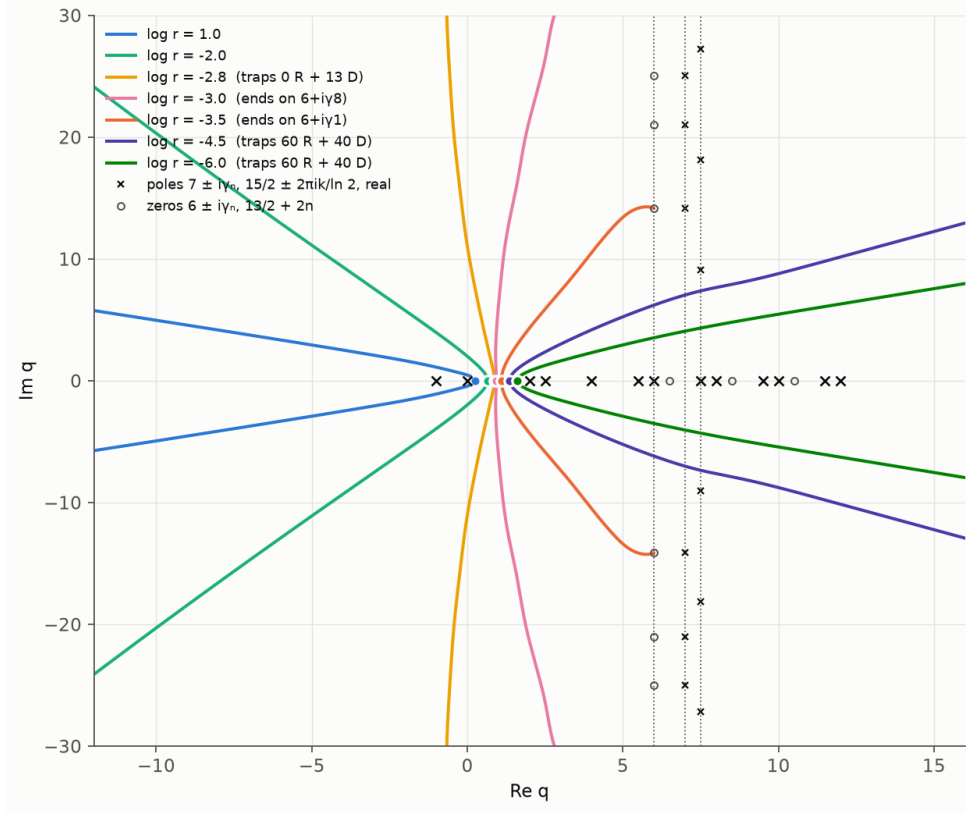


FIG. 2. Lefschetz thimbles of $\rho^q(-2Z_\eta(q))$ (odd ensemble) through the real saddles $q_0 \in (0, 2)$, for $\log \rho = 1, -2, -2.8, -3, -3.5, -4.5, -6$. Crosses are poles: the Riemann wall $7 \pm i\gamma_n$, the dyadic wall $15/2 \pm 2\pi i m / \log 2$, and the real poles. Circles are the zeros $6 \pm i\gamma_n$ and $13/2 + 2n$. Dotted lines mark $\text{Re } q = 6, 7, 15/2$.

dominates both, with period $\log 2$. Where every wall pole is trapped, the thimble's Stokes terms reproduce the full wall sum to 10^{-10} . The oscillations of α are at most 1.4×10^{-6} (at $\log \rho = -3$, next to the edge of convergence) and fall as $\rho^{5.5}$: they reach 2×10^{-9} at $\log \rho = -4$ and 8×10^{-11} at $\log \rho = -4.5$. At the same distance from the convergence edge, the oscillations of the spectral index are eight to nine orders of magnitude larger (Fig. 5). The reason is the factor $\Gamma(-p)$ in $M_\eta(p)$. At the walls its power growth $|p|^{-\text{Re } p - 1/2}$ compensates the exponential decay $e^{-\pi|\text{Im } p|/2}$, for example $|\Gamma(\frac{17}{2} - 2\pi i / \log 2)| = 1.8 \times 10^2$. In coordinate space this Gamma function is cancelled by the Fourier kernel, and only $|\csc(\pi q/2)| = 1.3 \times 10^{-6}$ remains at the first dyadic pole ($|\Gamma(8 - i\gamma_1)| = 0.33$ against $|\csc| = 4.6 \times 10^{-10}$ at the first Riemann pole). The number theory of the Euler ensemble is thus clearly visible in the spectrum [6] (Fig. 6). In the structure function it is present but unobservably small, and it

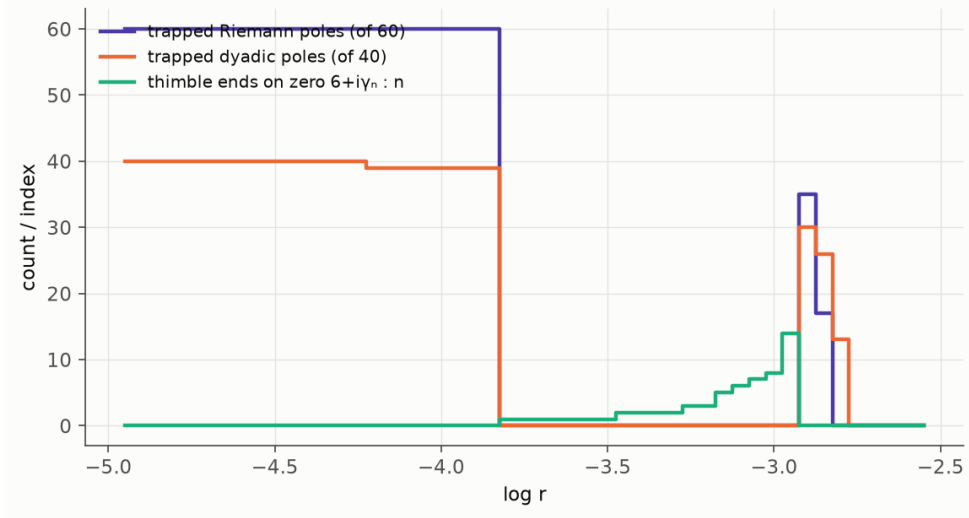


FIG. 3. Stokes staircases of the structure function: the number of trapped Riemann poles (of 60) and dyadic poles (of 40), and the index n of the zero $6 + i\gamma_n$ on which the thimble parks.

is completely absent at large separations.

E. Finite-size correction

The Euler ensemble describes homogeneous turbulence in infinite space. In a system of finite width W the modes $k \lesssim \pi/W$ are absent or non-universal. In the scaling variables this is a cutoff $\kappa > \kappa_{\min} = \pi L(t)/W$, and the structure function becomes

$$D_W(\rho) = 2 \int_{\kappa_{\min}}^{\infty} d\kappa \left(1 - \frac{\sin \kappa \rho}{\kappa \rho}\right) H(\kappa) = D(\rho) - 2 \int_0^{\kappa_{\min}} d\kappa \left(1 - \frac{\sin \kappa \rho}{\kappa \rho}\right) H(\kappa). \quad (16)$$

The infinite-system $D(\rho)$ is the thimble result. The subtracted infrared part is computed from the small- κ expansion of H . Closing the contour of (6) to the right, only the poles of $\Gamma(-p)$ contribute, and

$$H(\kappa) = \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} \frac{(-\kappa)^n}{n!} A_n, \quad A_n = \frac{f(n) \zeta(n + \frac{15}{2})}{(2n+7)(2n+17) \zeta(n + \frac{17}{2}) (1 - \eta 2^{-(n+17/2)})}. \quad (17)$$

Since $f(n) \sim C^n$, this is an entire function of κ . It reproduces the Mellin integral to 10^{-15} for $\kappa \leq 40$, and $\frac{\pi}{2}H(0)$ equals the large- ρ coefficient a_1 of $G(\rho)$. The index $\alpha_W = \rho \partial_\rho \log D_W$ uses $\rho \partial_\rho (1 - \sin x/x) = -\cos x + \sin x/x$. The lower endpoint of (16) leaves a term $\propto H(\kappa_{\min}) \cos(\kappa_{\min} \rho) / (\kappa_{\min} \rho^2)$. As a result α_W oscillates about zero with period $2\pi/\kappa_{\min} \approx 2W/L$ in ρ , periodic rather than log-periodic, and first dips below zero near

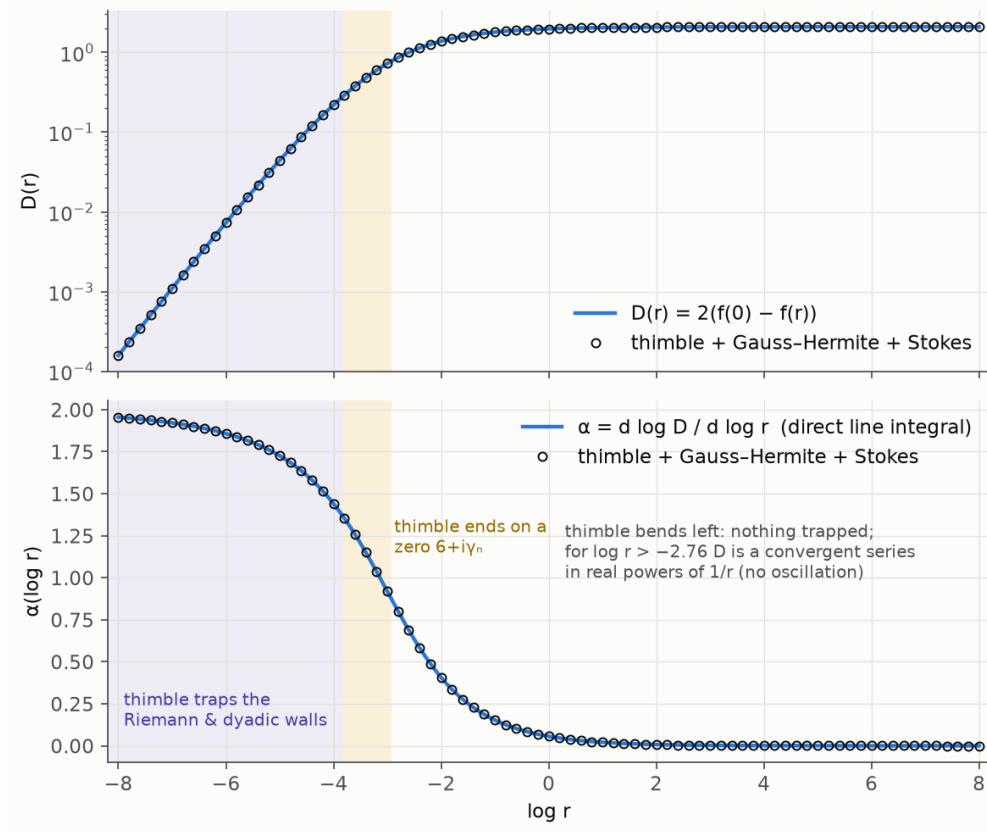


FIG. 4. The structure function $D(\rho)$ and the effective index $\alpha(\rho)$ of the odd Euler ensemble (lines: direct contour integration; circles: thimbles with Gauss–Hermite quadrature and Stokes terms). The shaded bands mark the zero-parking (orange) and wall-trapping (violet) regimes.

$\rho \approx W/L$ (Fig. 7). These are the only oscillations of the index at large separations. An earlier evaluation of the index with the spectrum integrated over $0.1 < \kappa < 1000$ [10] found exactly such oscillations at large ρ ; they are the finite-size oscillations of (16) with $\kappa_{\min} = 0.1$.

III. WIND TUNNEL AND DNS DATA

A. The Max Planck measurements

We use the second-order structure functions $S_2(r)$ measured in decaying turbulence in the Max Planck Variable Density Turbulence Tunnel by Küchler, Bewley and Bodenschatz [9], for 11 runs with $Re_\lambda = 413$ –5779. These are the full data sets behind Ref. [9], provided by the authors. The measured index is $\alpha_{\text{exp}} = d \log S_2 / d \log r$, computed by centered differences.

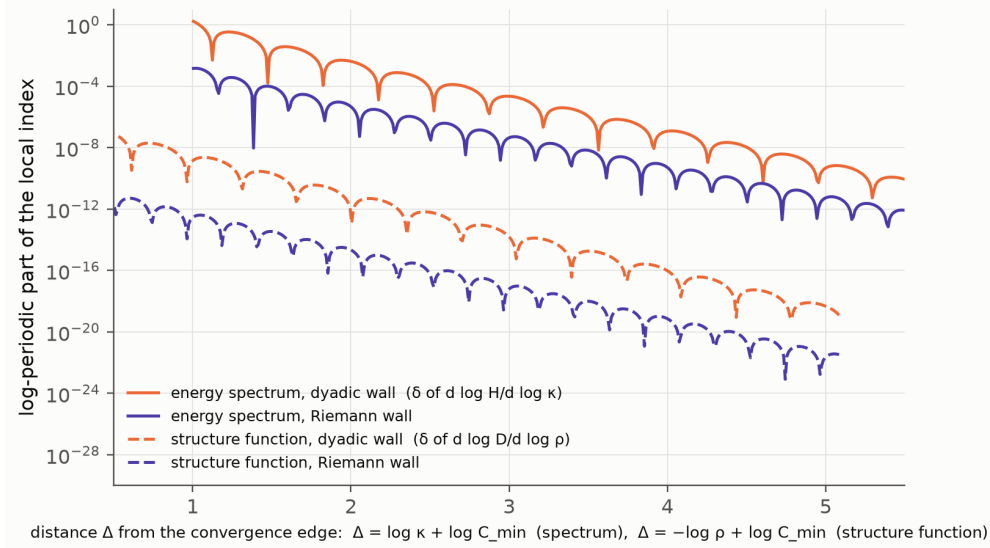


FIG. 5. Log-periodic (wall-pole) part of the local index: energy spectrum, $\delta(d \log H/d \log \kappa)$ (solid), against structure function, $\delta\alpha$ (dashed), for the dyadic and Riemann walls of the odd ensemble. The horizontal axis is the distance from the edge of convergence of the corresponding residue series, $\log \kappa > -\log C_{\min}$ for the spectrum and $\log \rho < \log C_{\min}$ for the structure function.

The unknown normalization of S_2 drops out of α .

In grid turbulence the decay time is the distance from the grid, $t = z/\bar{v}_z$. The theory's variable is $\rho = r/\ell_D$, with diffusion length $\ell_D = \sqrt{\tilde{\nu}(t + t_0)}$. The index depends only on ρ , so a single parameter per run, $s = \log(\ell_D/\eta)$, converts r/η to ρ . The files also give u' and the Kolmogorov scale in physical units, assuming SI units for S_2 and ϵ . The viscosity inferred from Re_λ and from the dissipation range agree to 1–20%, and η ranges from $133 \mu\text{m}$ to $8 \mu\text{m}$. The integral scale $L = \int_0^{r_0} R dr$ of each run, with $R = 1 - S_2/2u'^2$, is 0.1–0.4 m. The fitted diffusion length is $\ell_D \approx (7\text{--}9) L$ in every run.

Each run's large- r tail ($\alpha_{\text{exp}} < 0.355$, beyond the inertial plateau, which the theory does not contain) is fitted by $\alpha(\rho)$ with rms deviation 0.014–0.045. At the largest separations several runs show small oscillations of α_{exp} , with dips to $-0.03 \dots -0.1$ (Fig. 8). The infinite-system index cannot produce them: it is positive and monotone there, and its intrinsic oscillations are below 10^{-6} . The finite-width correction (16) reproduces them. With $\kappa_{\min} = \pi\ell_D/W$ fitted per run, the rms deviation drops by up to a factor of 2.5. The implied physical width is $W = 2.25\text{--}2.6$ m for five of the seven runs with $Re_\lambda \leq 2398$, of the order of the largest measured separations (2.3–3.6 m). A single $W = 2.34$ m for these seven runs lowers

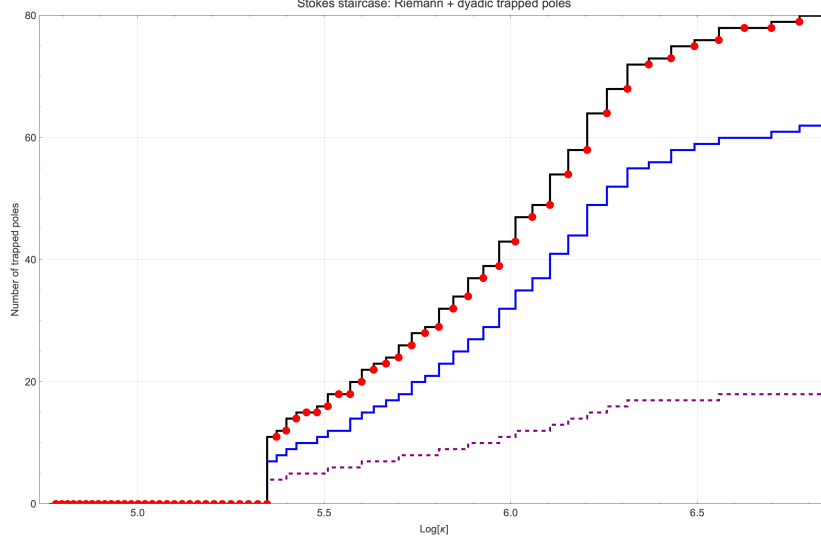


FIG. 6. Stokes staircase of the energy spectrum in the odd Euler ensemble, from Ref. [6]: the total number of trapped poles (black, dots), Riemann-wall poles (blue) and dyadic-wall poles (dashed) as functions of $\xi = \log \kappa$. Each trapped pole adds a log-periodic correction to $H(\kappa)$.

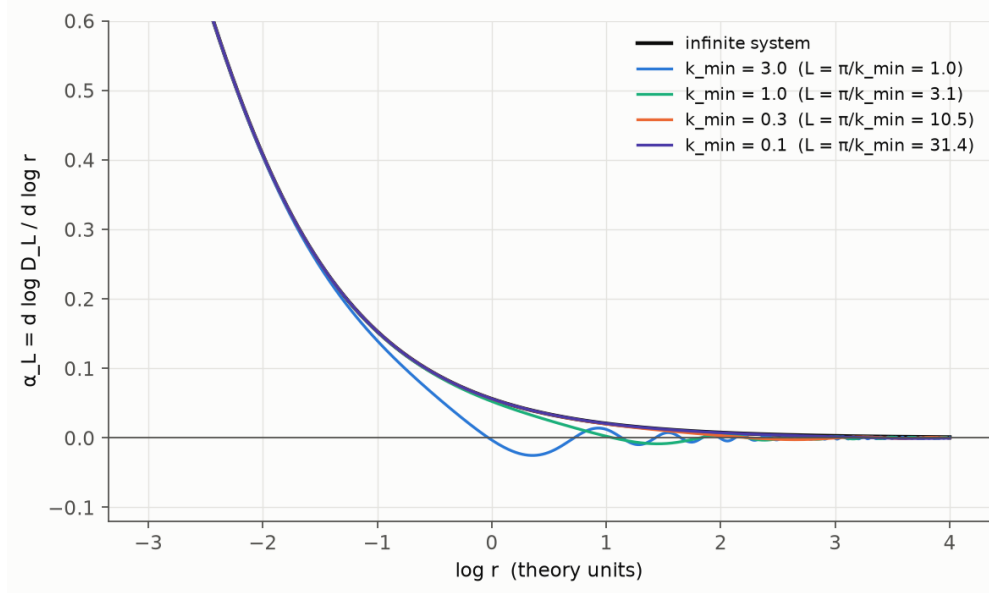


FIG. 7. The effective index of the finite system, Eq. (16), for several infrared cutoffs $\kappa_{\min} = \pi L/W$, compared with the infinite system.

their pooled rms deviation from 0.035 to 0.023. The runs with $Re_\lambda \geq 3070$ show no dip and do not constrain $\kappa_{\min}$. We conclude that the observed oscillations are finite-size effects. Their amplitude does not exceed the statistical scatter of the data at the largest r , and they

runs used	$s = \log(\ell_D/L)$	χ^2/dof	weighted rms of α
all 11 ($Re_\lambda \geq 413$)	2.075 ± 0.024	2.8	0.018
$Re_\lambda \geq 1046$ (adopted)	1.956 ± 0.021	2.4	0.017
$Re_\lambda \geq 1305$	1.943 ± 0.020	1.3	0.015
$Re_\lambda \geq 2033$	1.847 ± 0.015	1.9	0.016
$Re_\lambda \geq 2398$	1.823 ± 0.017	2.0	0.012

TABLE I. Fit of the odd-ensemble index to the Max Planck data extrapolated to $Re_\lambda \rightarrow \infty$ in $1/Re_\lambda$, for different sets of runs.

are not properties of decaying turbulence in infinite space.

B. Extrapolation to infinite Reynolds number

The theory describes the limit $Re_\lambda \rightarrow \infty$. To compare with it we extrapolate the data, not the theory. Each run is put on the data-defined scale $x = \log(r/L)$, and at fixed x we fit $\alpha_{\text{exp}}(x, Re_\lambda) = \alpha_\infty(x) + c(x)/Re_\lambda$ over the mid- and high-Reynolds runs ($Re_\lambda \geq 1046$). The theory $\alpha(\rho)$ with $\log \rho = x - s$ is then fitted to the extrapolated tail $\alpha_\infty(x) < 0.355$, with weights $1/\sigma^2$ from the extrapolation. The result is shown in Fig. 9. A single parameter, $s = \log(\ell_D/L) = 1.956 \pm 0.021$ ($\ell_D/L = 7.07 \pm 0.15$), gives $\chi^2/\text{dof} = 2.4$ and a weighted rms deviation of 0.017, with residuals within ± 0.02 over the whole tail. The finite-width term is no longer needed: fitted, it goes to $\kappa_{\min} \rightarrow 0.6$ without improving χ^2 . The negative dips of the individual runs do not survive the extrapolation, which confirms that they are finite-size, finite-Reynolds effects.

Table I shows the stability of the result under the choice of runs. The fit quality is stable. The scale ratio ℓ_D/L drifts from 8.0 to 6.2 as the lower-Reynolds runs are dropped, more than its statistical error, so part of the Reynolds dependence of the integral scale is not captured by the $1/Re_\lambda$ term. The even ensemble gives an index within 0.0035 of the odd one on this range and the same χ^2 (2.422 against 2.423), so the tail does not resolve the parity. It is fully consistent with the odd ensemble, the only stable one.

C. Direct numerical simulation

The same theoretical index has been compared with the 4096^3 DNS of freely decaying turbulence by Sreenivasan and Rodhiya [11], where the time dependence is available directly and the scaling variable is $r/L(t)$ [5]. The parameter-free theory reproduces the whole nonlinear curve of the effective index (Fig. 10). The deviations at the largest r/L come from the finite box and from early times, when $L(t)$ is still small [5]. They are the numerical counterpart of the finite-width effect in the wind tunnel.

IV. CONCLUSION

The steepest-descent evaluation of the Mellin–Barnes integral, with Lefschetz thimbles, Gauss–Hermite quadrature and the Stokes phenomenon, gives the Euler-ensemble structure function and its effective index with a relative accuracy better than 10^{-9} . The same Riemann and dyadic walls that produce the Stokes staircase and the log-periodic oscillations of the energy spectrum [6] are present in the structure function. There the Fourier kernel cancels the Gamma function that makes them visible in the spectrum. The index is therefore smooth: its log-periodic part is below 10^{-6} and vanishes identically at large separations, where the structure function is a convergent series in real inverse powers of ρ .

The small oscillations of the index observed at the largest separations in the Max Planck wind tunnel are reproduced by the finite width of the tunnel. They disappear when the data are extrapolated to infinite Reynolds number, and they are of the order of the statistical scatter or below it. They are not a property of decaying turbulence in infinite space. The extrapolated tail of the measured index matches the odd Euler ensemble, the only stable turbulent attractor, with a single scale parameter. The 4096^3 DNS reproduces the whole index curve. This is one more verification of the number theory of turbulence.

Wind-tunnel experiments with a larger cross-section, reaching larger separations in units of the diffusion length, and at higher Reynolds numbers, would separate the finite-size effects from the bulk dynamics. They would also test the predicted tail $\alpha \simeq a_1/(G(0)\rho)$ over a longer range.

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DECLARATION OF GENERATIVE AI IN THE WRITING PROCESS

The numerical cross-check in Python, the analysis of the wind-tunnel data and the first draft of this manuscript were prepared with the assistance of generative AI (Claude, Anthropic), following the author's instructions and his *Mathematica* notebooks. The author verified the scientific content and takes full responsibility for the manuscript.

DATA AVAILABILITY

The *Mathematica* package, the driver notebook and the independent Python implementation of the thimble computation, together with the scan tables and figures, are available in Ref. [12] (folder `Mellin`); see also [10, 13, 14]. The Max Planck data of Ref. [9] were provided by the authors on request and are quoted with their permission; they are available from the authors. The DNS data of Ref. [11] are available on request from their authors.

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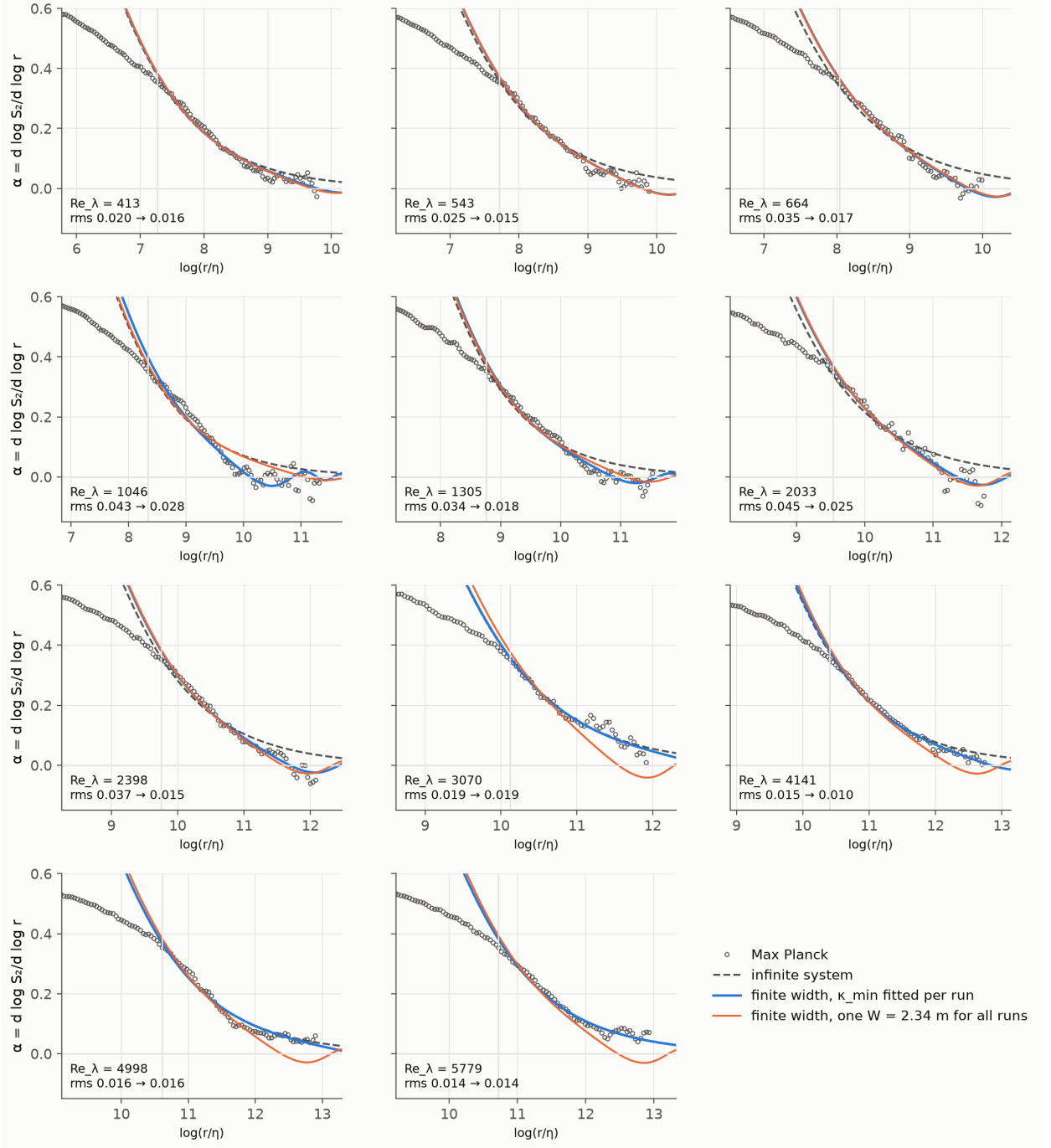


FIG. 8. Large- r index of the Max Planck runs [9] (circles) against the infinite-system theory (dashed), the finite-width theory with $\kappa_{\min}$ fitted per run (blue), and one physical width $W = 2.34$ m for all runs, $\kappa_{\min} = \pi\eta e^s/W$ (orange). The vertical line marks the start of the fitted tail. The labels give the rms deviation without and with the per-run finite-width correction.

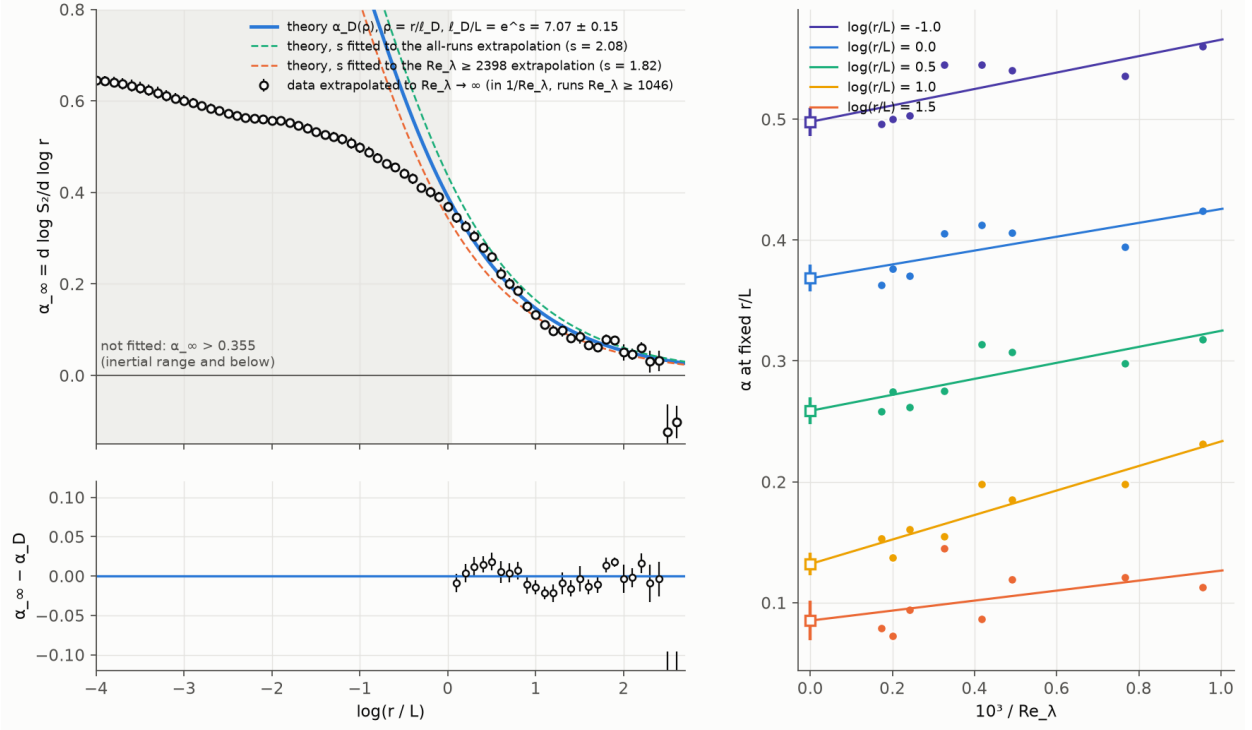


FIG. 9. Left: the Max Planck index extrapolated to $Re_\lambda \rightarrow \infty$ in $1/Re_\lambda$ (circles, runs $Re_\lambda \geq 1046$) against the odd-ensemble theory with one scale parameter (blue). Dashed lines use the shifts fitted to the extrapolations with all runs and with $Re_\lambda \geq 2398$ only. The fit uses the tail outside the shaded region; the residuals are shown below. Right: α_{exp} against $1/Re_\lambda$ at fixed r/L ; squares are the extrapolated values.

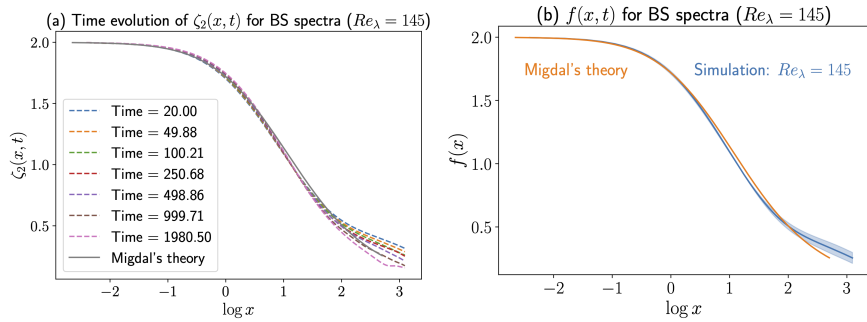


FIG. 10. Effective index $\langle r \partial_r \log(\Delta v^2) \rangle$ of the 4096^3 DNS of decaying turbulence by Sreenivasan and Rodhiya [11] (Birkhoff–Saffman initial spectrum) against the Euler-ensemble prediction (from Ref. [5]).